Who Is There, and When?

A worksheet for mapping an ordinary week of your mother's help.

Ask anyone in the family who helps your mother and you'll hear “we all pitch in.” This worksheet asks for the longer answer: which day, which person, which job.

Pick an ordinary week, not a holiday week and not the week someone was away. Fill in over a few days, then show it to your mother and ask what you've missed. Where you don't know, write “don't know” and leave it.

The week, day by day

For each day, who comes by, who calls, who drives, and roughly when. Use names. At the top, write which week this is and who filled it in.

FOR EXAMPLE Tuesday: my sister picks her up at ten for the hairdresser and the grocery store, home by one. Most mornings: the neighbor looks in around eight.

The standing jobs

The jobs that don't belong to a day, like the pill box, the bills, the pharmacy run or the yard, and who does each. Include the ones your mother does herself.

FOR EXAMPLE Pill box: I fill it on Sundays. Bills: she pays her own. Pharmacy: whoever happens to be going.

When she is on her own

The stretches of an ordinary day and night when nobody is there and no call is planned. Write the times. Whether they matter isn't a question for this page.

FOR EXAMPLE Most afternoons, from about one until I phone at seven. Overnight.

What each piece counts on

For each person above, finish the sentence “This works as long as…” Their work schedule, where they live, their car, their own family.

FOR EXAMPLE Tuesdays work as long as my sister keeps Tuesdays off. Mornings work as long as the neighbor lives next door.

Who could cover

Next to each helper, the person who could step in for a week. Only write a name if that person has said yes. Otherwise write “nobody yet” or “haven't asked.”

FOR EXAMPLE Tuesday drive: nobody yet. Morning look-in: maybe the couple across the street. Haven't asked.

Small things you've noticed

One specific thing per line, with where and when you saw it. Write what you saw, not what you think it means.

FOR EXAMPLE Sunday: held the rail with both hands coming down the back steps. Two of Thursday's pills were still in the box on Sunday.

What this shows you

Three things: who is there and when, what each part of the week counts on, and which parts have nobody behind them yet. It doesn't show whether the help is enough or whether anything should change. Nothing here adds up to a score or a level, and the things you've noticed go to her doctor, her pharmacist or your care consultant, who are the ones to say what they mean.

Ready for the next step?

You've put your mother's week on paper, with the names and the days. The care interview sets that week beside the rest of her situation, going area by area so nothing is left out, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

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